his gun-shaped lighter. A few pages later, we see Sanjay Dutt on set. Much like the guns in the foreground, his cop's uniform is also pointedly, hilariously fake.

"I think all photography is fiction," says Singh. "And I wanted people to read the book like you would a thriller. When something was becoming too predictable, I had to pull the rug out from under your feet. This is something I learnt from Hindustani classical musicians. You must stop a concert just before people say '*Bahut ho gaya* (that's enough)'."

For her first project as a graphic design student, Singh spent six winters photographing Zakir Hussain and other Hindustani classical ustads. In *Let's See*, we meet these maestros backstage. It is in the green room that we see them inhabit a hyphenated space, between preparation and performance, between private and public. Refreshingly, Singh's focus is the *mahaul* (ambience), never the *mehfil* (gathering). "When I travelled with musicians, I was probably a bit of an oddity. Nobody thought of me as a photographer. Photographers were big men with big cameras. I was not using a zoom or even a wide angle. Making photographs became a way of listening for me, of continuing the conversations."

There are a few images in *Let's See* that one can't forget—a dishevelled Kishori Amonkar being comforted by an older woman, Ustad Ali Akbar Khan watching Ustad Vilayat Khan sing—but only when Singh appears in mirrors herself does one feel startled enough to ask, 'Are we reading a novel or a memoir?' Singh says, "It partly is a memoir. I didn't set out for it to be like that. But since it was a conversation, I couldn't keep myself out of it. It wasn't me and them. It was us. It was our world."

Having won this year's Hasselblad Award, Singh also recently saw photographer Palini Kumar receive the first Dayanita Singh-PARI Documentary Photography Award. Not one to be swayed by recognition, Singh says, "Often, I don't even call myself a photographer because I don't like the limits that photographers have set on photography. I can't let the boys club box me into being a 'photographer'." ■

-Shreevatsa Nevatia

PHOTOGRAPHY

Portrait of a People

An ongoing photo exhibition in Mumbai wants visitors to see the Parsi community in a new light

In the 'Parsi Nose Project', fashion photographer Porus Vimadalal recasts the representation of the country's robust Parsi community in popular culture. The series of images trains its gaze on Parsi noses, distinguishable by their large proportions, and caricatured often, as a harmless physical identifier of a Parsi everyman. It is this stereotype that Vimadalal reclaims in his photographs, overwriting a traditional depiction of his community from a completely different vantage point. In that, the 'Parsi Nose Project', displayed as part of a showcase titled *Hearts on Fire–Reflections on Parsi Photography: Past, Present and Future*, subverts the legacy of the Parsi identity by forcing the viewer to confront its evolution.

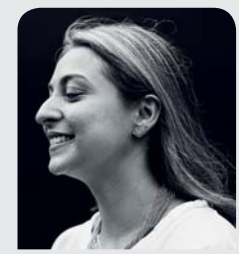
Much of the exhibition, available to view at Chemould Colaba until October 15, alternates between disrupting a conventional way of seeing a community and considering the diverse facets of contemporary Parsi existence. Curator Sarica Robyn Balsari invites 11 emerging and veteran photographers, one designer and a calligrapher to shatter the assumption that the Parsi identity is a monolith. For Balsari, the idea of inviting both Parsi and non-Parsi photographers was a conscious decision–the distinct backgrounds of the artists, she hoped, would underline the importance of contrasting perspectives. The photos featured in the exhibition range from staged portraits to candid observations, juxtaposing the certainty of the past with the possibilities of the future. As traditional portraits co-exist with contemporary formats like reels and music videos, the overall effect is that of a medium-agnostic time capsule into history and memory.

Take,for instance, filmmaker and photographer Sooni Taraporevala's set of sepia-drenched portraits that situate everyday Parsi existence in the distant past, each frame revealing a story withheld from public consciousness. Bindi Sheth's 'Majji ni Life,' on the other hand, is a set of black-and-white images that capture the candour of modern Parsi existence, the community's zest for life, and its reverence toward family. Sheth's images are deceptively simple: they isolate faces and bodies while centering them, prodding the viewer to arrive at her own interpretation.

Themes of aging and loneliness seem omnipresent throughout the images featured in the exhibition. One Sunhil Sippy portrait, for instance, captures an old Parsi couple longingly gazing out of their window; another Divya Cowasji image titled 'Minnie Mama, Navroz Day', foregrounds the celebratory spirit of the community. Balsari's curation feels revelatory in its scope, encouraging viewers to expand their understanding of a community whose fate seems unfairly set in stone. The result is both rewarding and sobering, a timely reminder that casts the community as an unfinished portrait in varying stages of being. ■

-Poulomi Das

The 'Parsi Nose Project' subverts the legacy of the Parsi identity by forcing viewers to confront its evolution





A FRESH LENS
(top to bottom) The 'Parsi Nose Project' (2022-present) by Porus Vimadalal; 'Ardeshir Reflects' (2021) from Sunhil Sippy's Tardeo series (2010-present); 'Group Therapy' *(2022)* by Avinash Jai Singh

